

Chapter 107 - Jealousy

The news of Divine Venerable Chu Ling's return quickly spread throughout the four seas and eight wilderness¹, with celebrations continuing for several days. Especially Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, which had been silent for many years, was decorated with lanterns and colored banners for several days, filled with joy and celebration from top to bottom.

Since the Divine Venerable perished thirty years ago and Mei Chengsi also died in the chaos, Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate had been without a sect master. Although Elder Pingyao managed affairs in the interim, they had ultimately lost prestige among the six great sects, becoming weak in overall strength, no longer what they once were.

Now that Chu Qingqiu had returned, she would naturally resume the position of sect master. How could this not make everyone overjoyed?

The momentum celebrating Chu Qingqiu's resurrection was grand, yet the protagonist of the resurrection made no commotion, as if death to her was merely a dream of Nanke², and awakening now was nothing extraordinary.

Purple Cloud Peak remained entirely pristine white, the accumulated snow uncleaned, as cold and desolate as it had been years ago.

A barely perceptible wind blew through, and a few flakes of thin snow fell from the treetops. The surrounding barrier transmitted slight fluctuations as two figures, a man and a woman, appeared at the cliff's edge. The woman wore black robes, half-covering her face, showing no signs of abnormality.

The man appeared somewhat disheveled, his hair ornament and outer robe both askew. He awkwardly reached up to straighten them, glancing at the unresponsive woman beside him.

"Strong as a monster..." Wen Yao Jun muttered, then properly adjusted his attire and walked toward the towering stone hall within Purple Cloud Peak.

Black Scale raised her eyes and said to be careful.

As soon as she spoke, a jade-white bone flute descended from the sky. Wen Yao Jun hurriedly stumbled backward, and when he looked down, the bone flute was embedded in the footprint he had just made, immediately breaking out in a cold sweat.

He cupped his hands and said: "Wen Yao Jun of Penglai Realm disturbs Divine Venerable Chu Ling. I beseech the Divine Venerable's forgiveness!"

Long after his words fell, many frost flowers drifted down from mid-air, brilliant and dazzling. A fragrant breeze arrived before the person did, immediately causing Wen Yao Jun's face to redden as he dared not look further.

Two footprints appeared in the snow, and a woman in plain gauze emerged at the end of the frost flowers, walking through the snow.

In earlier years, people only heard of Divine Venerable Chu Ling's exceptional immortal power and prowess in battle. Though some spoke of her appearance, it was merely a scattered embellishment beyond her strength, not much regarded by the world.

Thus, seeing her now for the first time was truly shocking.

She stood amid the north wind and snow, pure and unadorned throughout her body. Three thousand soft strands of hair fell behind her, her dark eyebrows were slender and flew into her temples, her peach blossom eyes half-open and half-closed as she gazed at the ground, only lifting when she drew near.

Her lips were red as cherry fruit, adding a touch of humanity to her jade bones and icy skin.

That frost originally had no temperature, yet Wen Yao Jun felt piercingly cold for a moment. He lowered his head into his palm, saying anxiously: "Wen Yao Jun, under orders from Heavenly Emperor Tianrui, comes to congratulate the Divine Venerable."

"I have never known him, no congratulations are necessary," came the ethereal female voice. "If there is business, speak directly."

"The Emperor says that the Divine Venerable has twice slain demons, earning the respect of the six realms. But now the demonic seeds remain uneliminated, and the six realms will not find peace in the future. I wonder if the Divine Venerable could join forces with our Penglai to lure those demons into the world and completely eradicate them, bringing true peace to the six realms."

"Demonic seeds?" Chu Qingqiu raised an eyebrow.

Wen Yao Jun lowered his head even further: "Precisely the demon race that disappeared from the world after that great battle thirty years ago—Ning Fuyi."

As these three words were spoken, Wen Yao Jun's mind immediately buzzed as if hundreds of blade edges were ringing in unison. He was terrified beyond measure, nearly kneeling from this sudden killing intent.

"Divine Venerable, this..."

The killing intent ceased abruptly. When he looked up again, only indifference and contempt remained in the woman's eyes.

"Thirty years ago, Penglai took advantage of my sacrifice to slay demons and, without a word, invaded Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, destroying our halls and injuring our disciples. I have yet to settle this account with you. Yet you dare come seeking me instead?"

"It was merely coincidence. At that time, the Emperor calculated where that world-destroying person was located. Fearing she would cause chaos, he urgently entered Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. Though it was discourteous, it was for the peace of the world."

"I hope the Divine Venerable will be magnanimous and not blame us," Wen Yao Jun spoke beautifully, leaving no openings.

Chu Qingqiu looked at him for a long time before her gaze fell on Black Scale, who had been staring at her. Under this gaze, Black Scale quickly lowered her head.

Storm clouds gathered and dispersed in those peach blossom eyes, finally returning to calm.

"But Ning Fuyi is a disciple of my sect, and the successor of Sect Master Ningtian³. To expect me to believe empty words—do you think I died for thirty years and awoke a fool?" Chu Qingqiu habitually reached to touch the bracelet on her wrist, but finding nothing, she gently rubbed her wrist instead.

"Naturally, it won't be empty words." Wen Yao Jun heard this and produced a pearl the size of a bowl from his palm, using the wind to pass it to Chu Qingqiu.

Inside played the world-destroying signs from a star divination plate, with the protagonist being Ning Fuyi in black clothes and black robes. Chu Qingqiu watched expressionlessly until the image froze on her face, the two blood-stained beauty marks⁴ vivid and striking.

Chu Qingqiu returned the pearl without change of expression.

"This is a prophecy that our Penglai obtained by trading two thousand years of opportunity after two thousand years of closed-door cultivation. Does the Divine Venerable still doubt its authenticity?"

Seeing that Chu Qingqiu remained silent, Wen Yao Jun wiped the sweat from his brow in this icy weather and continued persuading: "Divine Venerable, our Penglai's prestige in the six realms is evident. Since our purpose is to protect the six realms, we are allies. If you are willing to help Penglai, it will surely bring stability to the six realms."

The woman stood silent for a long while, then suddenly let out a light laugh. This smile vanished in an instant, yet it made both people present pale.

Not only because of the surrounding cold, but also because when the woman smiled, she was like gorgeous flowers blooming in yesterday's winter.

When the smile disappeared, she was once again the cool and cold Chu Qingqiu.

"I'm afraid I must disappoint the Emperor. After my physical reconstruction, my immortal power has not yet recovered. Now, let alone eliminating demons with you, even flying a few li⁵ makes my entire body weak. I'm afraid I cannot help you."

"Please return." She glanced at the two of them, then turned to leave.

Wen Yao Jun wanted to pursue and say something more, but an unknown force like a giant whale's tail swept him entirely off Purple Cloud Peak.

He flew directly over the mountains and crashed into a barren hilltop. He awkwardly extracted his head from the bushes, turned to see Black Scale land steadily, quietly adjusting her hem.

He immediately filled with anger, rising to awkwardly straighten his attire: "Did the Emperor send you to be a stone? Not saying a word is one thing, but not even lifting a hand?"

"The Emperor said not to fight with the Divine Venerable," Black Scale finally spoke, her voice smooth.

Wenyao Jun angrily spat out the melted snow in his mouth before resuming his proper appearance, standing with hands behind his back: "I don't know why the Emperor said not to care whether the Divine Venerable lived or died thirty years ago, yet now wants to desperately win her over."

"Could it be that seeing she couldn't die, he determined she's no ordinary person?" he asked, frowning.

Black Scale said nothing and turned to walk down the mountain, causing Wenyao Jun to stamp his feet in place again: "What's the use of talking to you? Truly casting pearls before swine!"

On Purple Cloud Peak, Chu Qingqiu did not return to the hall but assessed her recovered qi and blood, estimating it was enough for one journey. She then took flight, transforming into points of light and heading southeast.

Her spirit was urgent, and along the way she forgot to avoid clouds, becoming covered in moisture and frost.

By the time she reached Gunan County, the sky had darkened. She flew along the river all the way until she saw the familiar hillside, then urgently descended. When landing, she was somewhat unsteady and nearly fell into the accumulated snow.

Chu Qingqiu supported herself against a willow tree bent by the weight, steadied herself, then hurried up the slope.

The closer she got to the small house, the more urgent her heartbeat became. When she stood before the door, her heartbeat could no longer be suppressed.

The door opened with a creak, greeted by cold, desolate air. Chu Qingqiu paused, lit a lamp, and entered.

Everything she saw was familiar yet distant⁶. The tea cup that hadn't been put away still sat on the table, the tea inside long dried.

The bed still bore traces of two people having slept there, but touching it revealed it was already cold, clearly no one had rested there since.

Nothing in the room was missing except for the wooden box that held the medicine pills.

Chu Qingqiu stood by the bed for a long while, unconsciously clenching her hands until her palms hurt, then releasing them.

She closed her eyes, then turned and ran down the slope. This time she didn't linger, raising her hand to break open the door.

A massive creature rushed toward her. Chu Qingqiu gripped the door frame and raised her hand to catch the excited Bai Lin⁷, who was about to faint, letting its four paws frantically flutter as it whimpered.

"Bai Lin." Chu Qingqiu used her gentle hands to stroke the white tiger's soft fur, her voice unprecedentedly tender.

Usually she was kind to Bai Lin but never embraced it, yet now she no longer rejected this feeling of embrace.

She unconsciously stroked Bai Lin's back repeatedly, lifting her eyes to look into the room, hope quickly fading.

The room was ice-cold and empty.

Chu Qingqiu suddenly felt a bit cold, even though she was born from ice and snow and should have been accustomed to the chill.

Yet without that person's warmth, it was still cold.

After a moment, Chu Qingqiu led Bai Lin, who wouldn't leave her side, down to the foot of the mountain. Four graves stood quietly here in the dim twilight.

She placed two materialized gardenia flowers before the first two graves, then stood before the third.

"My beloved, Su Mo." She read aloud in a low voice.

She stared at those words for a long time until her eyes ached, then turned toward the surrounding mountains, scanning each one with her reddened eyes.

Since the birth of her first strand of soul⁸, she had always been taught to be filled with great love⁹, but now for the first time she felt jealousy.

The object of her jealousy wasn't any other person, but that original, unchanged self who had experienced nothing.

The sky grew darker and darker until the characters on the tombstone could no longer be seen clearly. Chu Qingqiu finally placed a flower before the grave, then walked toward the last one.

It was a small grave, the tiny mound somewhat endearing, with a small stone tablet standing on it, the surface smooth and nameless.

Chu Qingqiu lightly curved her finger, and the grave split open from the middle, revealing a small wooden box and the body of a parrot with curled feet inside.

"You blocked an attack for me and should have had your divine soul scattered, but that demon race was already powerless before death, so one soul and three ethereal souls¹⁰ remained. In reincarnation, you could only become beasts and birds."

"Now I use the only remaining flower petal from my original body to help you reshape your human form. Are you willing?"

The clear female voice echoed through the mountains. A feather from who knows where drifted and flew over, landing before the grave.

Seeing this, Chu Qingqiu nodded and pulled a white hair from her dark temples. The white hair instantly transformed into a withered leaf.

Then the woman raised and lowered her hand decisively. A drop of heart's blood flowed from the blade tip, and the withered leaf instantly returned to spring, its green meaning fresh and lush.

Chu Qingqiu's body bent slightly, her lips losing their color, but she made no sound. Her three fingers pointed toward the grave, and scattered points of light rose from within, seeping into the green leaf.

The green leaf slowly grew countless veins, the veins intertwining like vines to form a woman's tall body, gradually growing flesh and torso.

Finally the veins disappeared, and the green leaf completely transformed into a human body. Her striking eyes were tightly closed as she lay in the snow.

Chu Qingqiu waved her hand to collect her body, then staggered and sat down. Seeing this, Bai Lin whimpered and rushed behind her, catching her with its warm fur.

The white tiger's tears fell from its night pearl-like large eyes, melting a large patch of snow.

Chu Qingqiu's hand rubbed its belly, her soft body leaning into its embrace as she gazed at the sky.

"Bai Lin, she left long ago and won't return, right?"

This was everything she had once desperately wanted, but why now did she feel no happiness at all?

¹ Four seas and eight wilderness (四海八荒) - A Chinese expression meaning "everywhere in the world"

² Dream of Nanke (南柯一梦) - A classical Chinese idiom referring to a vain dream or illusion

³ Ningtian (凝天) - The previous sect master, literally meaning "Condensing Heaven"

⁴ Beauty marks (泪痣) - Moles positioned like teardrops, considered a mark of beauty in Chinese culture

⁵ Li (里) - A traditional Chinese unit of distance, approximately 500 meters

⁶ (unsure translation) The phrase "恍若隔世" suggests a feeling of things being from a different lifetime

⁷ Bai Lin (白麟) - The white tiger's name, meaning "White Qilin"

⁸ Soul (心魂) - In Chinese cultivation, refers to one's spiritual essence or consciousness

⁹ Great love (大爱) - Universal compassion or love for all beings, a concept in Buddhist and Daoist philosophy

¹⁰ One soul and three ethereal souls (一魂三魄) - In Chinese spiritual belief, humans have multiple souls/spirits with different functions